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Jay Leonhart

Jay Leonhart is a first-call bassist as well as a talented singer and songwriter. He was born in 1940 in Baltimore, and received his music education at Berklee School of Music and Oscar Peterson's School for Contemporary Music. By the early '60s, Jay was performing with top jazz artists including Mike Longo and Buddy Morrow. He has recorded with Marian McPartland, Jane Jarvis, the New York Swing Trio, and numerous vocal artists. He is currently devoting an increasing amount of time to his songwriting and singing endeavors.

Jay was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 15, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today in San Diego for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to have Jay Leonhart with me, who I'm going to say is one of the most in-demand bass players in New York City. Is that right?

JL: Well, I certainly work a lot, and I know that a lot of people like me to play for them so yeah I guess it's true. I mean I don't want to be overly humble or anything, but at the same time I think it's probably true.

MR: What's a working week like for you in New York City?

JL: Well it's changed. I've been there for thirty years, coming in and out, you know I mean playing, sometimes going on the road a little bit. But a week at its peak involves a lot of recording sessions. I have two kids who are now 23 and 26 as of today, which is February 15, 1998 —

MR: Last time I looked.

JL: The cameras make you forget. They are 23 and 26. When they were young, I didn't want to leave them. As they were growing up I didn't want to be an absentee father at all. I mean for their sake, but mostly for mine. I enjoyed them so much. Because one of the real joys of my life is having these great little kids around. And I just wouldn't leave. So I tried to entrench myself in whatever music I could in New York City, and nearby. And I was lucky in that I got to be relatively busy as an electric bass player in the studios. And I learned to play it very well, you know a lot of the stuff, I mean I loved it, I loved the instrument, I wasn't faking. I did enjoy the instrument and still do, I just don't play it anymore, because I'm 57 now and there's not a lot of calls for a 57-year-old bass player who plays — doesn't play half of what the guys are playing now. So you know it's a very limited position I hold. And so it's all right, because I work a lot on upright, which is what I started off as anyway, you know, from dust to dust. And really I express myself much more fully on upright bass. And I do a lot of sessions. I don't do as many now, there just aren't as many sessions now for some reason. The business is scattered out and

they don't use as many live musicians, and the writers are younger and they use their friends who are younger. So I don't get as much of the work. Nonetheless I still seem to do an awful lot around New York.

MR: What kind of recording sessions would you have done on the electric bass? Was it T.V. shows?

JL: T.V. shows and jingles. Lots of commercials. All those innocuous — Crest commercials and so forth and so on. A lot of them I did.

MR: So at any moment you could hear yourself on the television?

JL: Unfortunately, yes. Well actually you know it's funny. On electric bass you didn't hear yourself so well because they always put you down in the mix. So you say I think I played that commercial. I started playing — the first really big commercial I did on upright bass was a Mazola commercial: [sings] Mazola is the da, da, da, da. And I started really using upright bass in a four-four jazz situation. I remember the date. It was like 1985, in August 1985, and that commercial became a big hit and everybody said you know, upright bass is good. And so they started using it, and started bringing it way up in the mix, and suddenly you could hear yourself on all the commercials. And they wanted someone who could play real jazz, who really knew his way around the instrument, and they used me anyway.

MR: No one else was available.

JL: Right no one else. So I got to be busier and busier, and I stayed around New York and people knew me, and so I just started making enough money in the commercials to hang around and play the jazz gigs at night, the occasional Broadway show, although I didn't like that, I'm too much a ham to be in the pit. I like to be on the stage with people saying I'm here to hear that music, that music's not to accompany that over there. So that's sort of what I did. That's why I'm here this weekend.

MR: Well I can tell you're a bit of a — you like to be on stage — I can tell by watching you.

JL: Yeah, sure.

MR: And we'll talk about your songs in a moment.

JL: No let's talk about them now.

MR: I don't want to talk about your songs right now.

JL: No, no, no, I'm just being —

MR: Now I can't get started again, let's see. No I understand you studied banjo at the Peabody Conservatory, is that right?

JL: No. That's a good, that's a pretty good misquote. This folks, is how things get misquoted. When I get accused of studying banjo at Peabody, you can see now the trouble we have. They didn't have a banjo major at Peabody.

MR: No kidding.

JL: No. I played piano at Peabody. And I was six years old, and I studied there, this was in 1946. My mother used to send me downtown on the bus by myself. It was perfectly safe. There was a statue in downtown Baltimore of a guy riding a horse, an English guy riding a horse with his arm out like this. My mother said, "When you see the horse and the guy pointing, Peabody's right — he's pointing right at Peabody. Get off the next block." I did. It was fine. The only trouble was is I, for whatever reason, didn't like to practice. I hated to practice the piano. I liked to play the piano. I didn't like to read. I had a block against learning to read. I just couldn't figure out what that was about. So I got to making up parts and things. And the teachers would say, "That sounds nice but what is that thing in the middle there?" And I'd be making something up to bridge the part that I knew to another part that I knew with the part that I didn't know. And I was sort of improvising. I really was improvising. And then I finally just couldn't take it. I hated going to the lessons at eight years old, unprepared. I felt so terrible. I felt like such a bad boy. I hadn't done my work, and I hadn't. So I finally cried my way out of the lessons. I like to think I was seven, I was probably fourteen. No but it was real early, and Miss Watson finally said, "This is too much stress on him, no more piano lessons." So fine, I stopped studying piano. I didn't touch the piano. Then all of a sudden Arthur Godfrey came on television about 1947, '48, teaching ukulele. And I got smitten, seriously smitten with the [scats] beautiful sound of the strings, it just sounded so beautiful to me. And now it sounds kind of — it still does sound very pretty to me. And Remo Palmieri was on television teaching Arthur Godfrey how to play. Remo Palmieri is a wonderful guitar player who now still lives in New York who I've since worked with a number of times, we're very good friends. So I got interested in string music. Banjo plucking. My brother immediately, my older brother saw that I liked the ukulele. He took the ukulele and mastered it in two seconds. He is the brilliant one. And I said what happened to my ukulele? All of a sudden I was playing second ukulele, plunking along, and he was playing all the lead, and I really liked it, I became a very good rhythm player listening to rhythms and harmonies and stuff. Took up banjo, studied guitar — studied — played it. Then at about fourteen, took up the bass, because I heard it in a Dixieland band and I realized here was my road to freedom. I could play my own instrument, didn't have to be my brother's lackey, he's playing all the lead and I can't even play a solo on tenor banjo, I was never asked to so I never learned to do anything except [scats]. And I was pretty good at that. I mean I developed a wonderful sense of time from it, really strong sense of where the time should be, trying to play good chords and stuff like that, and I was playing bass lines all the time. I was playing —

MR: Kind of like Marty Grosz. That style of —

JL: Exactly. Exactly. And then the bass came along, and Ray Brown entered my life with Oscar Peterson at the Stratford Shakespearean Festival, the record I think they recorded in '52, and that became the Holy Grail. That became the reason for living was that music for me. I mean it's amazing how powerful that music was to me. I never heard anything swing that like, I never heard arrangements like that, freedom, joy, everything expressed. Everything that I wanted out of this life was in that record, so I quickly bought it and listened to it thousands of times. I really became so centered on that music that it became really the center of my musical experience. Everything was happening — bop, Charlie Parker, I didn't care about that.

MR: Can you remember the very first time you heard that recording?

JL: Oh, clearly, clearly. John Eaton, the piano player in Washington who you may or may not know, he's a wonderful solo pianist, and he does a lot of concerts for the Smithsonian Institute, and he's a brilliant piano player. He made me aware of this record. And he sat down and he said, "You've got to hear this." I said okay. I sat down and listened to it, and like I said it really —

MR: That was it.

JL: Well it sure showed me what that bass instrument could be about. The sound, the drive, the beauty, it just overwhelmed me. And so I listened and listened. And to this day the way — the sound that Ray Brown got on that record, is to me the way I want the bass to sound. And sometimes I accuse myself, well why don't you become an original — why don't you do — and in many ways I'm very original. I write my own songs, I do a lot of things, I don't play the same notes that Ray plays, but boy I'm telling you, the spirit of his playing very much permeates my own, and he knows it. He and I have become very good friends, I went up to study with him, and I'll tell him blankly, I can't help it if you just played that well, anymore than he can help if Blanton played that well, and he copied Blanton and he admits — he heard Blanton and he said I've got to do that. But then Ray started swinging it more. Well I heard Ray and I said oh, that's how the bass has got to sound. And I naturally fell into my own way of playing and I find I'm really influenced by Oscar Pettiford, the melodicness — the melodicness — what's the word I'm looking for? Melodious?

MR: Melodiousness. That's worse. We know what you mean.

JL: But his melodic thinking. And he had a different approach than Ray did of course. But I liked lines that really tied together, that really expressed an idea, that didn't have to stop halfway through because technically you couldn't find the next note you were trying to say. Even if it's simple, just real notes. I mean like Gerry Mulligan, listen to Gerry Mulligan. What makes him outstanding is he learned to use the lower register. And he understood the sonic thing on the baritone, and so he played melodies on the baritone that

nobody else quite played. He had a melodiousness to his playing that it just comes through every time you hear — you hear two seconds you know it's Gerry Mulligan on the baritone, because there's a sonar — I don't know any words. Buy a dictionary and learn words like sonorous, melodicness, melodiciticity, melodocity — and use them. So some day, when you do an interview you —

MR: They'll just come right out. It was very sonorous.

JL: I wasn't prepared for this. And I'm a writer.

MR: No. So when you got into the bass, what did you feel, in addition to learning to physically play it and get that part down, the technique, did you then realize that there was a whole repertory of tunes that you had to get into? And how did you go about that?

JL: Boy I was speaking to Bucky Pizzarelli about this yesterday. He and I were of a generation, we never sat down and learned music. We heard it on the radio. We heard all the songs on the radio that anybody ever played. They were the pop songs of the day that became the jazz standards of later on. And I never sat down and studied a song. I'd always heard it on the radio. I mean well I might write out some substitute changes for it, but I heard so much jazz and you heard so many versions of it, that you knew 27 different substitutes for every song anyway. I rarely sat down and studied songs. Because I'd heard them all. Most people did pop songs, then of course when people started writing jazz songs, which in the bop era they started really writing, well I guess before that, but as far as I was concerned that's when they really started writing, bop. But even then you heard, somehow you heard those. Okay. And a bass player didn't have to study the leads to these things, which I now spend much more time doing, because as a solo player to be able to walk up and be able to do a solo version of a Charlie Parker song on just bass and try to make it interesting, it's great practice, I mean that's the way I practice now is to do that.

MR: Play the melodies.

JL: Play the melody and then try to accompany the melody. Like [scats], you know and take like "Donna Lee" and tear it apart. Don't just play the melody, but also accompany it and try to find ways to make it interesting on the bass. Meanwhile you're using your ear and you're solving all kinds of problems and melodic intervals and things, and playing melodies is good because you're forced to play stuff that you wouldn't think of in a solo situation on the bass. You know, solo-wise you're going to play something that you can play. But all of a sudden you've got to play the melody and you're forced into learning other things. But I don't want to play classical melodies, because I'm not going to use them. Unless they're really fascinating to me, I'd rather play something that I really want to hear.

MR: So like "All the Things You Are," tunes like that, the stuff from *The Real Book*, or the third of it that people really play, those tunes were being played on the radio by artists —

JL: Oh you heard them constantly. I mean don't forget, pop radio in those days, in the '40's and '50s, this was, I mean in the '40s, all it was was big bands and maybe some corny pop songs. I don't want to put anybody down but like Rosie Clooney's a good friend of mine, but her "Come Ona My House" songs in that category, which seemed to be the pop. But in spite of that there was all these wonderful songs from Broadway and the standards, and Irving Berlin and Porter and everybody. That's all you heard on the radio. And you got to know those songs inherently. So *The Real Book*, you look at it, you laugh. I mean you grew up hearing those songs. So that's what I don't envy about guys who have to, these days they've got to sit and really work to get the music. But then they become very well rounded because now they're into all the styles of music too. They're hearing all the music of the day. I mean jazz is always evolving hopefully, and changing.

MR: Eventually you went to New York?

JL: Yeah. I went to New York in 1960 — no that's not right — '61. I went up to Oscar Peterson's School in Toronto in '60, I remember turning 21 in a little apartment, on a cold winter night in Toronto on December 6th. All of a sudden I said I'm 21. I bought myself a quart of beer and celebrated. And Mike Longo, the pianist who you may know, he and I had a trio with a drummer named Jimmy Young, and we moved to New York together in April of '61. I started working at the Playboy Club and —

MR: Was there pretty fierce competition for gigs like that?

JL: Well I guess there was but we were some pretty capable players at that point, and we were young, we were able to put up with the hours, and somehow we got the gig. And there was lots of musicians working in New York, you know I mean there was plenty of guys. Gee in 1960 it was a very busy period, and still is. It's still very busy. But we got our jobs, and I could play reasonably well, so when I played with people a lot of them wanted me to play with them again. And that's the key you know. Somehow they say let's use that bass player again, the band sounded good, or let's use that drummer. Somehow if you can get that going, you're on your way to starving.

MR: You're well on your way to starving.

JL: You're well on your way to starving as a musician. You've worked those gigs you cannot possibly afford to make a living at. But you know you have to find a way. And that's the thing about music, you just have to find a way to make a living at it.

MR: What was a club date paying in the early '60s?

JL: Well I think — I went on the road, let me see I went on the road with Woody, no not with Woody Herman, with Buddy Morrow's band in 1959, '60, for $150 a week, and saved almost all of it, came back with more money than I had ever had in my life. Then I went

to New York, I think I was making $150 a week in 1961. I mean whatever that came to a night, it was six nights. And I was paying rent and my apartment was $150 a month, I had six rooms, five rooms on Riverside Drive for $150 a month, and I could have kept it. I could have kept it and today it would be $600. But I gave it up, and left New York in 1963. I had been drinking too much. You know I was a kid and I just wasn't in shape for that kind of thing. And I was messing around and drinking and so I left, unhappy, in '63, and went back to Baltimore. I started to work for my father, and realized that — I started working in the insurance business with my father in his company. And I went to a sales course and I realized wait a minute, you can't be drunk and you can't be drugged and sell life insurance. You just — I'm not going to do it. It finally dawned on me. And I said you probably can't play music well either in that condition. And it took me four years to really stop drinking, to really start care of myself, which I did. And in 1967 I moved back to New York. I really wanted to play. I knew I didn't want to — and I was completely sober. And I was able to really tackle the difficulties of earning a living as a musician.

MR: You know besides the fact that you're in night clubs so much, and that you're around booze, do you think that there's an attitude with some musicians that you kind of need to be high, on some substance or other, to play jazz?

JL: Yeah. Sure. I mean I know guys, very good musicians who at times in their lives really felt that they played much better drunk, high, whatever. And I understand that. I understand that. But it's hard to last like that. It's very tough on your system. And drinking is a perilous thing because it really takes it out of you. And you have that one little drink and just that one little drink, and you're in the club and somebody wants to buy you another and you say, oh, no, I've had my drink. Oh, no, no. Of course you're going to have a drink. Sure, sure, sure. Well what's another night down the drain. And if you're really serious about it, it's like an astronomer. He's going to go up and look at the stars — let's have a few drinks first. Really you want to see the stars, you want to see, you want to be able to look. If you're an astronomer, you don't want to be drunk, you want to really look at what you're doing. Well with playing music, hopefully it might be the same thing. And for me it has been for the last thirty years. And I don't mean to be preachy about it, but, okay.

MR: Good words. The list of people you've played with since then is most impressive: Gerry Mulligan you played with, Sebesky and Phil Woods.

JL: Yup, yup. Well being in New York and being in the studios, and being available, really available, I've had a chance to work with everybody. I mean just about everybody. I mean Miles Davis was one of the few I didn't work with, I could name a small list of people who I never got a chance to play with. But in one capacity or another, either in the

studios or a one-nighter, subbing for somebody, steadily, working steadily, or recording, I've really had a chance to work with a lot of people and hear a lot of music.

MR: And your children were born, let me figure, late 70s?

JL: Well, my daughter Carol was born in 1971, my son Michael was born in 1974.

MR: Okay. And that's when you started to — was your pick-up of the electric bass, no pun intended, that was about that time?

JL: No pun taken.

MR: Thank you. Was that about the same time? Did that happen because you wanted to stay home more, and the electric bass became something you needed to do?

JL: Well I never made any real courageous decisions about staying home, it was just sort of little teeny decisions. I took up the electric bass when I was twelve, in 1952. I bought a Humbucker, a Gibson Humbucker, because I was, I don't know, somehow or other I just bought one and my brother and I were doing a little bit of fooling around with it. And it was in my guitar days, it was before I took the upright up. So I played it, and I said yeah, I can play this, and I'm sort of playing it, and then I put it away. Then I moved to New York and all of a sudden I heard Aretha Franklin and Jerry Jemmott and I guess Chuck Rainey play. I said now I like that, that's good electric playing. I mean this is [scats]. I said, yeah, I could get into that now. So I got electric bass and I realized they were doing a lot of commercials, and the recording business was mostly on electric bass in New York, even in 1967 when I moved back to town. And I guess I just said I've got to buy one. I know I can play it, I know I've got the basics of it down. So I took a couple of gigs at night where I worked just playing electric bass, electric bass, and my upright chops went out the window but I didn't care because nobody was calling me to play. In those days jazz had sort of taken a deep dive underground. I mean the public just lost it. Jazz got so complex and convoluted and nobody was playing swing anymore, nobody was playing simple songs that non-jazzers could understand. So the public said well forget jazz. Rock & roll, that's what we like, rock & roll. And so what happened was is pop music started taking on the characteristics of early jazz. All of a sudden Aretha was — I mean certain areas of pop music were starting to take over where early jazz had been so communicative. To me, pop music was starting to do this. And then all of a sudden, so in the '70s jazz was in a very underground state. And in my opinion, the guy who caused it to turn around, now you'd never guess this, but in my opinion it was Scott Hamilton. He started playing jazz that people could relate to. And all of a sudden his music became very popular. Swing jazz. He came in sort of like Lester Young and started playing like this. And I watched this tremendous resurgence occur right around the time that he was really getting popular. Now I know it's a silly thing to say, but like people will say —

nonsense. This saxophone player whose name I've just blocked out, the last of the boppers — practiced on the Brooklyn Bridge.

MR: Oh, Sonny Rollins.

JL: Sonny Rollins, I don't know why I can't think, Sonny Rollins. He was playing all the time, but he had sort of gone underground. I mean people didn't hear these people. Coltrane is dead I think already, and so all of a sudden people like Stan Getz and Scott Hamilton, and Zoot Sims were sort of becoming heroes again. And it was very communicative, easy to understand music. And the public said oh, all right, I can understand that. So a lot of people who didn't know, could understand it. So they started to embrace it again. And then along comes Wynton, who's — gee I mean on one level he's playing his far out music, on another level he's playing so far in New Orleans music, march music. And God bless him. And a lot of the young guys today are very much traditionalists. You know I mean they're acoustic bass and they're playing. I mean they have the modern touch to it, a very modern touch and very technical, and great expertise. But jazz has sort of said, people sort of said well we've got to communicate. If we don't communicate, we're going to get lost.

MR: We're really going to starve.

JL: Because there's a couple of people who will get away with going out in front of huge audiences and getting out. There's always a couple of people who can get away with it. And everybody else says hey I'm going to do that, and they can't get an audience. Because the audience says, huh, yeah, come on, you know we're being very kind here. We don't understand what's going on but these are stars. So it goes like everything, it pushes the envelope and people go — they don't understand it. So I'm just looking at it from my parents' standpoint, and people who buy this stuff. You know they only sell three percent of the records in the country. So who's buying what? And if you want to make a living at it, I'm not saying sell out, God knows my kids, they're not selling out, they're finding out what it's about, they're doing their own music now. My son put out two records already. And he got wonderful reviews and he sold eleven records.

MR: What does he play?

JL: He plays trumpet. You know he graduated from school in music and art in 1992, won a Grammy as the outstanding musician in the country, the Grammy people, NARAS, the Grammy people did a contest, and he won this big award. He was also a presidential scholar in some other area for being in the arts. So bingo, he was a sudden person of the week on ABC news, this 18-year-old kid.

MR: You know now that you mention it, I know I've seen his name in the trades or whatever, and I didn't make the connection.

JL: Right. And he went around the world with this U.S. super band and he was getting more publicity than you can imagine. All of a sudden he's a songwriter, a singer, a pianist, a guitar player, a drummer, and all kinds of things. And a beautiful trumpet player. But he's just like spread out to here right now. So he's finding his way with music, extremely expressive, sometimes out, sometimes in, but it's gorgeous stuff, I mean I find it gorgeous stuff. So he's going to find his way in the world, and my daughter is a singer and they were both out with Steely Dan for instance, two years, they've both been on a world tour with Steely Dan. And they're good. I mean, trust a prejudiced father. And they're just trying to find their way. I don't know where we're going with this conversation.

MR: Well do you compare songwriting with — do you compare your songs with your son? Do you guys get together?

JL: Oh all the time, all the time. We talk. We don't try to write songs like each other, but I listen to his stuff and it leaks through. He's being as original as he can be, but I hear myself all the time in there in a certain way. But he's very original. Actually we don't talk technique of songwriting at all. We talk about the soul of the songwriting, writing about what's on your mind, and enjoying it. It's like a professional hobby with both of us. We're both very dedicated to it. And he's done, well I've done, I mean I just don't write pop songs, I just write stuff that's really on my mind, whether it's serious or joking, and sometimes joking is very serious to me. I mean it just is, that's just how I express myself.

MR: When did you first get into — have an urge to do your own songs?

JL: Well I wrote poetry in high school as a sort of a way to communicate to friends and have fun. And I found out I could write a limerick pretty easy, it's not that hard to do, the English language does have some rhymes in it, and if you think about it you can find them. Then in the 30s, all of a sudden I just — the kids were born and I wrote a sort of a Sesame Street song that I liked. A little silly and sappy and all that kind of stuff, but I liked it. Then we had a big gasoline shortage I think in '73 or '74, I mean a big one. And I wrote, "I'm thirteenth in line at the filling station/Waiting to pick up my weekly ration/Of gasoline/From a big machine." And I wrote a country song that actually got a little bit of airplay in the country, in the east. And I had a lot of fun putting it together and enjoyed the little bit of publicity and I said you know this publicity can help you in your music career. I said it can really not be a bad thing. You can get work, people know your name, and you might work in all sort of peripheral areas, even as a jazz bassist. So pursuing and promoting the songs was not something I didn't want to do. I loved writing them, thought it was something, the challenge, the fun of actually performing the songs, that you can actually earn a living at it, it's very expressive and everything, I mean it just became like a hobby that I really loved pursuing and felt very good when I was doing it.

MR: And what about the first time you decided you could deliver them yourself?

JL: Well I automatically assumed I was going to deliver them myself. I didn't think anybody was going to do them for me. I never even thought that I would be a songwriter for other people. I thought whatever level I achieve at this, I will do it, I will perform my own music, and anyone who hears them and wants to do them is free to do them. And as a result I have not spent any time, comparatively speaking, promoting my own music, which is a mistake in terms of economic, although I have survived economically so maybe it's not such a big mistake. I didn't get rich. If that's a sin well then that's the sin. But I do work consistently on it. I've got a show coming up on Broadway this fall, I'll be in it, an off-Broadway, and hopefully it will move up to Broadway. We'll see what level we're going to get it to, but it's seriously produced, of all my own music, just a story weave through which I've taken a list of about 150 songs that I've written and then picked the ones that I really love, that have something to say, that are funny, that are poignant, that to my way of thinking have something to say — excuse me as I bang the mic again. That have something to say, and turn them into a song with a little bit of chatter in between to sort of tie things together or maybe not. But it's easy to sort of find a way of weaving and not make it so totally self centered you know, but it's about the world, life, science, photon splitting and all kinds of songs. I mean I have a lot of songs. And we've done a couple of run throughs of it — or is it runs through — run throughs or runs through. Oh I figured out something the other day. Now did you know that the word "the" should be pronounced "thee" probably in front of a vowel and "the" in front of a consonant.

MR: Give me an example.

JL: "Thee" article, or the article. The article is hard to say. The article. But thee article just, just thee article. The ball is the ball. And you find that in the English language when you want something that flows nicely, the should be pronounced "thee" in front of vowels, and the in front of consonants. And I'm just walking through, now I'll probably have to write a song about that. Because that was never in an English book was it? Did you ever read that in an English book?

MR: No I never did.

JL: But in terms of pronunciation it always makes sense, that it should be the lamp, the book, thee aardvark. See but aardvark is hard to say but the aardvark is just thee aardvark. Thee, because of the a.

MR: Thee ideas you have are quite fascinating.

JL: Right thank you. See you caught on immediately, even better than I'd hoped.

MR: I'm going to try that in my next song. Actually it does flow nice, and I expect if I see your show on Broadway I expect the singers will be using that.

JL: I will probably be the only singer. But I think I have to write a song about that, because it's a very good idea. To let America learn how to speak our language.

MR: Well when you did your thing last night, your set last night, I mean in my opinion at these parties, it was a great change of pace, it was really something different, I really enjoyed it.

JL: Well thank you.

MR: And just the vocal note, with your bass line, those two things moving, great stuff.

JL: Yeah. I enjoy it. You know if you can get it to sound decent you can have a lot of fun with just being at the top and the bottom of Bach, leaving the middle two lines to someone else, you know you're the lead and the bass. And I mean I've done concerts of just myself, and it's great fun. And I've not gotten a bad review from it, because you've got to do awfully interesting material however. You've got to find ways to make it very interesting for the audience because you're going to walk out there with a bass, so you've got to have some interesting patter and have some fun and keep the songs flowing so their ears don't get totally exhausted by bass — voice — bass — voice. So you've got to find ways to get around things. And having Kenny Peplowski play with me of course is — what a player, what a sound he gets out of that clarinet. What a sound.

MR: Excellent. These jazz parties — when was the first time you did a jazz party?

JL: I think the first one I ever did was Otter Crest, which I don't know, have you ever heard of Otter Crest?

MR: No.

JL: Oh it's a wonderful one. It was up in Salem, Oregon, run by Bill and Mary Brown, and it was in this gorgeous setting overlooking the Pacific. What a beautiful party. And all of a sudden all these wonderful players come from all over and we'd get together in this idyllic little resort, overlooking the Pacific, and there are seals down on the rocks down below and stuff, and just that northern coastline — the northern California/Oregon coastline, which is overwhelming to a person from the east who's never really seen that, how different and how expansive and beautiful it is. And all these musicians from the west coast would come up and the guys on the east coast would get together and they'd have some really good sets. I mean it wasn't just traditional music, it was a lot of real swing — it never got past really swing, I mean a little bop maybe, it never got modern, modern. But they're catering to the audience, which at that time was mostly white people from 50 on. So you know you play the music they want if you want customers. It's the old customer thing you know.

MR: As it is at most of them.

JL: Right.

MR: In fact you see a lot of the same faces.

JL: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: They make the circuit.

JL: And they're getting older, and they're dying off, and I don't know what it's going to be with this kind of thing, but it's all right. There's no younger faces here. There's no younger people getting interested in this music. But they are certainly interested in their music. There is lots of music there, so we'll see what happens. I suspect there will always be a market for those of us who wish to play. The music that we're playing at this festival isn't exactly my cup of tea either. I mean while I love how — to miss New Orleans to [scats] — "Do you know what it means to miss New Orleans" — I can't play it every night now, you know? I mean this homage to older jazz gets a little tiresome to me. But then it's all right, because the players are great.

MR: Every once in a while it's fun to play that I guess.

JL: Yeah.

MR: And watch the group on stage work things out. I mean there's a lot of horn players up there.

JL: Yeah, and these guys, these guys know how to — I mean I'm not just saying it to cover my bases, cover my tracks here, but these guys are very good, I mean Peplowski and well, I guess maybe there's no sense listing them, but they're all very good players, and it's been a lot of fun. They know what they're doing. These are the pros of the pros in this business downstairs right now. They know just how to do it.

MR: Well you've got a play in the future, a musical. Have you got any recording plans coming up soon?

JL: Yes. Yes. I have a very ambitious project for myself. I am just getting into computerized recording now, and I'm going to create a whole series of recordings of just bass — solo bass songs of Ellington of this, that and the other thing, of different styles of music. I'm going to take also some classical themes and work on them, and see if I can play the classical themes and then find accompaniments to them, improvised accompaniments to them. And it's songs that I really love from the classics, I mean as well as Gershwin and Porter and everybody else, and put out a long series of records, put them out myself, of bass solos on these things. Because bass solos are funny things. If they're communicative, they find their way on to the air. Disc jockeys will play them.

MR: No kidding.

JL: The jazz guys will play a bass solo every once in a while, and they'll just for the fun of it, stick it on. Then I'm going to do a whole lot of new songs of my own, with probably my son accompanying me mostly because he's such a good keyboard player. And so I've got a lot of recording projects, just — big commercial plans in the recording world, no, I don't see any reason for it. I don't see what — I don't understand how I could possibly

pull it off. But I'll just keep doing my music and make it as good as I can, and I will try to sell it a bit more efficiently, through the Internet and stuff like that, and try to become a better salesman, as long as it doesn't stress me out too much. Maybe I'll just let other people —

MR: It's almost a whole job in itself to do that kind of thing. But you seem to have been very successful in finding a number of niches in the world of music.

JL: Yes, I think so. I mean I've got record companies who still sell all six of my CDs now, I'm still talking to all the presidents of them, and the records are still on the market, and they still sell. And I've got deals coming up in the future, just some other stuff, and of course with Bucky and John — Bucky Pizzarelli and John Bunch, the group that got called New York Swing, that's really a remarkable group to be in, I like this group very much, just piano, bass and guitar. And it's a very interesting combination of older music, newer music, but all swinging and beautifully arranged, and these guys can play.

MR: Yeah. I just, to me there's nothing like that chunking — what do they call it — hollow body —

JL: Yeah, rhythm guitar.

MR: I mean that just —

JL: That Freddie Green rhythm. Well Bucky's a master of that.

MR: Yeah. And it's also the notes he puts on top of the chord, too. I've noticed, in fact I wanted to talk about Milt Hinton a little, he was on a Dick Hyman record that I just think is great. And it wasn't just the chunking, it was the note as it moved on the top of the chord [scats], you know that voice leading.

JL: Well you know, I'll tell you a little secret. Most of the time there's one note in the chord. Most of the time Bucky's doing, he's dampening most of the notes and playing one, the third or the seventh [scats]. You listen carefully. There's not six notes, five notes, there's not even three notes. At best there's two notes. Two notes coming through and the rest of it is chunk, chunk, chunk, chunk. And you get that sensational combination of a drum [scats]. He is the simplest guy. And that's why he can play any song at all. He doesn't have to know all the upper partials of it. When there's a solo playing he'll play all the upper partials of it. But when he's playing rhythm guitar, and that's the key to it, that's why it sounds so good, because it's not notey and full of — and that's what rhythm guitar players today, young guys who will pick up a Martin steel string and start playing rhythm guitar on it, they're trying to play all the notes and they don't understand it doesn't sound good.

MR: It's way too thick.

JL: See, yeah, blang, blang, blang, and it takes too long for the [scats] for all those notes to — with Bucky it's [scats], it's really just two little notes. Always. Always. That's his key.

MR: Cool. I'm glad you told me that. I'll really listen for that. I know you had a nice part in the Milt Hinton tribute CD. I saw your name in there with a nice thing to say.

JL: Oh, yeah, yeah. The one he recorded, yeah. That song has not been recorded yet, that tribute that —

MR: No, that's not what I was talking about, but I know you had a nice sentiment in that double CD they put out that had that nice book in it.

JL: Right. And I put a poem in it, which is actually a song, which had been performed at his 80th birthday. I'm able to keep track of Milt's birthday perfectly because he is thirty days [years] to the day older than my wife. So when she has a birthday, he has a birthday and he's thirty years older. Yet somehow she's fifty years younger. Now that is an interesting bit of mathematics.

MR: I think you should write a song about that too.

JL: He's thirty years older than she is, but she is fifty years younger than him. She pulls it off every year.

MR: Well this has really been fascinating. I've been looking forward to talking to you.

JL: Thank you, it's been a great pleasure.

MR: And I wish you the best with your myriad of projects, and working on your vowels and the consonants.

JL: Oh, so much to do, so little time. So much to do, so little time. See there was no b's in there. Anyway thank you very much, Monk, appreciate it.

MR: Okay. Thanks for your time.